

Family Muscicapidae

Old World flycatchers

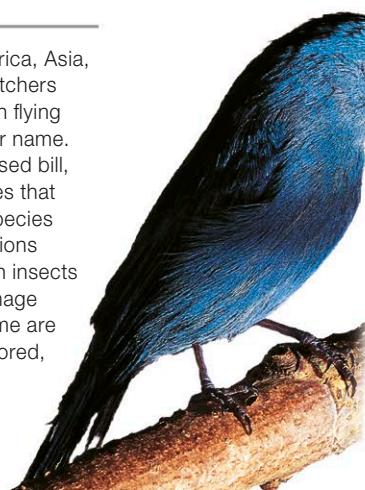
Length 10–21 cm (4–8½ in)

Species 301



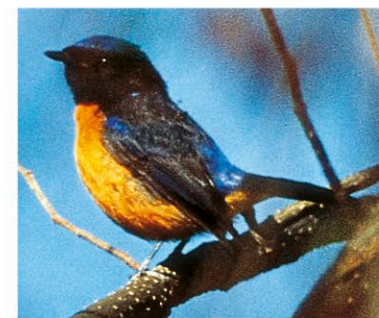
Distributed across Europe, Africa, Asia, and Australia, Old World flycatchers sally out from a perch to catch flying insects in their bill, hence their name. They usually have a broad-based bill, which is surrounded by bristles that help them catch their prey. Species that breed in the northern regions migrate south in autumn when insects begin to get scarce. The plumage of these agile fliers varies: some are brown, others are brightly colored, and the sexes frequently have different plumage. The male is often larger. Some species have a crest, and a few have bright facial wattles. Although

some of these birds sing well, most have harsh call notes, and the group as a whole is no match for warblers and thrushes. Most build an open cup in the branches of a tree or bush, where females lay 1–11 mottled eggs.



VERDITER FLYCATCHER

Eumyias thalassinus, measuring 6½ in (17 cm) long, is found from India to south China and south to Borneo. It often perches prominently and delivers a loud, sweet warble. The male is greenish blue, with darker wings and tail; the female is duller and grayer than the male.



RUFIOUS-BELLIED NILTAVA

Niltava sundara occurs from the Himalayas to southwest China and is resident in Myanmar above 3,300 ft (1,000 m). About 7 in (18 cm) long, it hunts for insects in low scrub and forest undergrowth. The male has a black throat, the female having a white throat patch.

RUFIOUS-GORGETTED FLYCATCHER

Found from Kashmir in north India through the Himalayas to southwest China, and in parts of Southeast Asia, *Ficedula strophilata* occurs in forest and forest edges above 3,300 ft (1,000 m). This bird is 5½ in (14 cm) long, the female having a smaller and paler gorget, or throat patch. It has 2 calls: a low croak and a high-pitched "pink."



NORTHERN WHEATEAR

Oenanthe oenanthe is the wheatear of Europe, Canada, and Greenland, arriving for the summer from its winter quarters in Africa. Its white rump and black "T" at the tail tip catch the eye in flight. It is 6 in (15 cm) long and eats insects. A bird of open uplands, it nests in crevices, old rabbit burrows, or under rocks; the female lays 5 or 6 pale blue eggs.

EUROPEAN ROBIN

Perky and bold, with a distinctive red breast, *Erithacus rubecula* is found in Europe, North Africa, and northwest Asia. Juveniles have a brown speckled breast and head. About 5½ in (14 cm) long, the European robin has a rippling song and a sharp "tic" alarm call. It feeds on insects and berries, and when on the ground, usually hops. The female lays 4–6 red-spotted, white eggs.



COMMON NIGHTINGALE

Luscinia megarhynchos is renowned for its long and varied song, heard most clearly at night. The song is delivered from within cover; in fact, the nightingale is notoriously difficult to spot. Found in Europe, North Africa, and Asia, it migrates south in autumn. Females lay 4 or 5 olive-brown eggs in a nest that is built in thick cover, near the ground. The nightingale is 6½ in (16.5 cm) long.



WHITE-STARRED ROBIN

Pogonocichla stellata has a yellow body and tail, a blue-gray head, and white patches or "stars" over both eyes. It is 6 in (15 cm) long, and reveals a white spot on the throat when it sings its creaking notes. It is found in highland forest in eastern Africa, from the Cape to Malawi.

BLUETHROAT

There are 2 European subspecies of *Luscinia svecica*: the Scandinavian form (pictured left) with a red throat patch, breeding in willow and birch forest; and the continental form with a white throat patch, which nests on swampy lakesides and scrubby ditches. There are other subspecies such as *Luscinia svecica magna* in Turkey, which has an all-blue throat. All forms are 5½ in (14 cm) long.



Family Passeridae

Old World sparrows and relatives

Length 4½–8 in (11–18 cm)

Species 51



Patterned in browns and grays—occasionally with yellow or black patches—sparrows are gregarious seed- and insect-eating birds of open woodland and desert. They often spend much time feeding on the ground and many live alongside

human habitations—some species even entering cities. Most lack the weaving skills of the related Ploceidae, but build bulky untidy nests of twigs or grass. Some species are colonial when breeding, others solitary.

HOUSE SPARROW

One of the world's most familiar urban species, *Passer domesticus*, is 6 in (15 cm) long and lives easily with humans. It originates from Asia, but is now seen in many countries, although population declines have been noted.



Family Ploceidae

Weavers, widowbirds

Length 5–9 in (13–20 cm)

Species 109



This is a large, mainly African, group of finchlike birds, most of which are known as weavers. They have short, conical bills, short, rounded wings, and plumage that is usually yellow or brown, sometimes both. Some species look confusingly similar.

Most weavers build roofed nests, some with long, downward-facing entrance tubes. In some, the males are brightly colored when breeding and have a courtship dance; females may also choose their mate on the quality of their nests.

SOCIABLE WEAVER

Restricted to Namibia, Botswana, and South Africa, *Philetairus socius* nests in large colonies of up to 300 birds, the nests adjoining each other in a huge mass on trees or poles. This bird is 5½ in (14 cm) long.

